

One hundred years ago

The idea of intelligent Martian life reached a peak at the turn of the 20th century, when a wealthy businessman, Percival Lowell (1855–1916), set up his own observatory in Arizona, USA, and began to study Mars.



Lowell claimed he could see a network of lines criss-crossing the surface of Mars, which he believed were built to transport water from the poles around the planet.

Martians sell books

We now know the lines weren't there, but many people believed Lowell's theories, caught up by the excitement of the idea.

The discussions inspired H. G. Wells' *The War of the Worlds* – a book published in 1898.

Illustration from
H. G. Wells' book
The War of the Worlds.

In 1938, a radio dramatization of H. G. Wells' book by Orson Welles frightened around one million Americans because it described the Martian invasion of the Earth in the form of a news report.

